

LEARNING TOGETHER

The Opportunity to Achieve Universal Education



Shiksha Alochana
September 2021

Learning Together: The Opportunity to Achieve Universal Education

An action oriented study conducted in West Bengal

By

Shiksha Alochana

(A collective of teachers and educationists)

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Contents

Foreword by Sukanta Chaudhuri	5
Chapter 1. Introduction	13
Chapter 2. Alternative processes of teaching-learning during the pandemic	25
Chapter 3. Challenges ahead and way forward	51
Appendix Tables	71

FOREWORD

The Covid pandemic has worked havoc on India's fragile and unbalanced education system. The extent of the damage has not attracted the attention it urgently requires. Understandably, it has been overshadowed by the more immediate damage to life and well-being by the pandemic itself. Less understandably, in fact unpardonably as a nation, we have not looked beyond the real but remediable problems of privileged children to the alarming educational deficit opening up in our young generation as a whole. Several crores of Indian children might be left totally without the basic survival skills of literacy and numeracy, if extraordinary measures are not taken to counter the loss.

The problem will not go away once schools reopen; rather, that is when it will reveal its full extent. It cannot be solved within the normal curricular framework, or by the inadequate cadres of teachers in often ill-equipped schools. A special programme has to be created, and dynamically adjusted to the vagaries of the pandemic. It has to be implemented in mission mode, with community participation alongside formal schooling, which might continue to be impaired in the foreseeable future.

Fortunately for West Bengal, we have a large, committed, innovative network of teachers across the state under the banner of *Shiksha Alochana*. Over the years, *Shiksha Alochana* has provided a forum for primary-school teachers of Bengal (and sometimes beyond) to exchange ideas and experiences. I know from my personal interaction how enriching those exchanges can be. Most importantly, they are now finding expression in reports and publications that can be accessed by a wider public.

In our country, teachers even at tertiary let alone primary level are commonly told what to do: no-one is interested in what they have to say. With every passing year, the education system is shaped more and more without reference to the persons who will execute it. So when a body of teachers, bound by nothing beyond their commitment to the profession, give voice to their thoughts and experiences – soberly, analytically, drawing practical conclusions from facts and observations without partisan rhetoric – the exercise takes on even more value than usual. *Primary Education in West Bengal: The Scope for Change* (2018) was a valuable report. The present publication, *Learning Together: The Opportunity to Achieve Universal Education*, may prove even more valuable.

This is for three reasons. First, *Learning Together* records the plight of primary education during the pandemic, and the human condition

of the children shut out from school. Second, it offers a set of concrete, practical steps to reach out to the children, not only pedagogically but to ensure their total well-being, which has often been impaired to an extent we prefer not to face. Third and most important: these proposals, and the outlook they embody, can be the starting point of an agenda of educational consolidation beyond the special context of the pandemic, compelling though that is. If the community of teachers, the state authorities, and – most important of all – our wider society, functioning as an active participatory body as well as a pressure group, can all come together, we might possibly overcome the national inertia that still pegs India's literacy rate (to look no further) at 74 per cent, and Bengal's just two percentage points higher.

I am awestruck by the optimism of the subtitle of this report, *The Opportunity to Achieve Universal Education*. We are fortunate in having a substantial body of teachers in our state who can think so big even in this most disheartening of times, and propose a practical template for reform. Let us not fail them, so that we do not fail our children and our nation.

Sukanta Chaudhuri
Professor Emeritus, Jadavpur University



Glimpses of the Report

- As one study finds, 92 per cent and 82 per cent of the children have lost foundational abilities in Language and Mathematics respectively owing to Covid-19 school closures.
- Despite significant socio-emotional losses of the children, less attention has been paid to this aspect in research policy and practice aimed at improving students' education and development. Our experiences in the respective neighbourhoods reinforces the above.
- The departmental initiatives of online teaching and supplying the children with worksheets were found to be far too inadequate.
- Some of the teachers and other social volunteers have developed ways of teaching-learning, including (a) in-person teaching by maintaining the health norms, and (b) by using telephone, internet, and other communicative media.
- Despite such societal initiatives, the learning achievement of a large section of the children was found to be terribly lacking: from a quick assessment of 7204 students of primary classes we found that a quarter of the children had 'very poor' level of competence; corresponding figures for 'satisfactory' and 'average' were 44 per cent and 32 per cent respectively.
- A survey of the economic conditions of parents carried out in 369 households showed that children enrolled in the government run primary schools came

mainly from working class background (day labourers, cultivators, and petty traders). Households have suffered huge loss of income during the pandemic. Consumption of cereals, pulses, fish, meat, and vegetables has declined substantially (percentage figures being 14, 22, 33, 44, and 24 respectively).

- Children have their own rights to equitable education. Their vulnerable social background, which was further devastated by the pandemic has increased the social imperative of ensuring equitable education for all manifold. This adds to the urgency of re-opening of the schools and all the activities including the serving of cooked Mid-day Meal being resumed.

Possible actions for resuming the schooling processes

1. Preparing the ground: The first task is to prepare the ground for resuming school in person. This requires wide-ranging discussions at various levels. Given the immense variations in the local situations the discussions cannot but add priority to a decentralised mechanism.
2. Preparing the schools: Since schools have effectively remained closed for a long time, it is urgent that they be cleaned and properly sanitized.
3. Bringing students back to school: This can only be done by involving the local communities, including parents and others, by different means – from convening meetings at school to visiting the hamlets and homes.

4. Preparing for lessons: It may not be possible to resume classes instantly. Children need to be provided with a setting that allows them enough room to acclimatize to the situation. One of the most important tasks for teachers will be to listen to the children individually. Teachers have to prepare themselves in a newer way to discover children in their full potential.
 5. Beginning the lessons: Classes should be organized in a manner that does not let the children feel that they have been away for so long. They have to be made acquainted with the school in a friendly way, without being burdened with workload.
 6. Baseline assessment: Given the gap in schooling, it is centrally important to know the levels of competence of each student, and hence, they have to be assessed through a baseline exercise, which could be called Minimum Most Essential Learning Outcomes.
- It is a collective responsibility, of both government and society, to come to terms with a situation that has threatened the country by causing enormous harm to the educational prospects of children. The government may have a shortage of resources but that should not deter it from gathering the will power to face the challenge, especially when many of the social segments are more than ready to come together to carry forward an initiative to save the children's future.

Community driven
educational initiative -
Birbhum



Chapter 1

Introduction

Behind a posh shopping mall in the smart city called New Town there is a road-side tea-shop run by a woman. In her shelter in a squatter colony, not very far from the shop, she lives with her two daughters, and fear – the fear of eviction from the place she has occupied to run her shop, her only livelihood support. Not long ago, one of us was visiting the area and stopped by the shop for a cup of tea. The two daughters were studying their textbooks. They were students of standard 5 and 3 respectively in a local primary school. Our colleague was rather impressed on seeing them busy studying, and wanted to wish them well. At that point the mother kept quiet, with a bit of annoyance put on her face. But the moment our colleague asked her permission to take a photograph of the girls with the books, she became furious: “What makes you come here? Do you enjoy our penury? Is it funny that our children have to study sitting here at the tea shop? Who are you to ask us questions? Did anybody help us? Look at the children, they have just received these books from school. But, tell me, who will teach them? How can they learn? Just go away, let us fight our own battle.” The sisters grew pale, as if they had committed some crime which made their mother unhappy.

Education in the time of the pandemic

Children are not well, nor are their parents. Are the educators well? No. We can vouch for at least a section of them. If the long school closure has an etiolating effect on the children, it seems to have pushed at least a section of the education activists to the state of being neurotic delinquents.¹ Having been one of the most active sections of the society, the present state of inaction thrust upon us is hugely frustrating. We are reduced to being mere spectators of a catastrophe that has robbed the chlorophyll off the lush green leaves – the children. They are parts of our lives; without their association we are stripped of our identity. This sense of helplessness is further added to our sense of not being able to do justice to our social contract through which we earn our living. More salt is added to injury when some sections of the society accuse us of not carrying out the work we are paid for. This menace is not a sword hanging exclusively upon us. Children across the country are facing the terrible effect of school closure. As a study finds, 92 per cent and 82 per cent of the children have lost foundational abilities in language and mathematics respectively owing to Covid-19 school closures.²

- 1 Melitta Schmideberg (1947), Psychological Factors Underlying Criminal Behaviour, *Journal of Criminal Law and Criminology*, 37(6)
- 2 AzimPremiji Foundation Research Group (2021), Loss of Learning during the Pandemic: Field Studies in Education, <https://azimpremjiuniversity.edu.in/field-studies-in-education/loss-of-learning-during-the-pandemic>.

A UNICEF report indicates that the global situation is no less worrying.³ Professor Sukanta Chaudhuri has summarised the Indian situation in a terribly disturbing essay:

Each year, some 2.4 crore Indian children enrol in Class 1. Barring a small fraction of the privileged, the batches of 2020 and 2021 have effectively not taken the first step towards literacy and numeracy. A large proportion of those enrolled earlier will not have acquired the skills, or forgotten what they acquired. By a ballpark estimate, 8 to 10 crore children in primary school currently cannot read or count.⁴

A recent report carried out in 15 states by volunteers guided by academic-activist Jean Dreze et al show a very dismal picture of learning achievement of the students of standards 1-8. Only 28 percent of rural and 37 percent of the urban students were studying at all.⁵

3 UNICEF (2020) https://www.unicef-irc.org/publications/pdf/COVID-19_Effects_of_School_Closures_on_Foundational_Skills_and_Promising_Practices_for_Monitoring_and_Mitigating_Learning_Loss, https://www.unicef-irc.org/publications/pdf/COVID-19_Effects_of_School_Closures_on_Foundational_Skills_and_Promising_Practices_for_Monitoring_and_Mitigating_Learning_Loss.pdf

4 Chaudhuri, Sukanta (2021), Missing school, missing meals: Without remedial action, the pandemic will cause a terrible learning deficit in tomorrow's workforce, The Times of India, 22 August, <https://timesofindia.indiatimes.com/blogs/toi-edit-page/missing-school-missing-meals-without-remedial-action-the-pandemic-will-cause-a-terrible-learning-deficit-in-tomorrows-workforce/>

5 The School Team (2021) *Locked Out: Emergency Report on School Education*, <https://drive.google.com/file/d/1VxH2QRZmOTTO9vMvzugb9wbEA9OJXuVF/view>

The point of concern, however, is not only this gap in and loss of learning. Reports from across the globe are terrifying: despite significant socio-emotional losses of the children, less attention has been paid to this aspect in research policy and practice aimed at improving students' education and development.⁶ As we see children in the neighbourhoods suffer from socio-emotional stress on the one hand and enormous, almost irrecoverable, academic losses on the other, our suffering multiplies. It is further deepened by witnessing the dehumanising effect of Covid-19, and some of the measures taken to tackle it, on the parents whose children we have been working with. The reader should not be surprised that some of our colleagues had to undergo counselling from colleagues, friends, and practising psychiatrists. If this be the case of the teachers, the degree of suffering of the children, most of whom are unable to communicate it to others, can well be imagined. This report is a result of that imagination of social suffering, which induces us to do as much as is in our power to shake off the inaction thrust upon us and find ways to give back to the children their childhood.

Social motivation to keep the flame alive

The authors of this report are mainly primary school teachers of

6. RISE (2021) The Importance of Students' Socio-Emotional Learning, Mental Health, and Wellbeing in the Time of COVID-19, <https://riseprogramme.org/publications/importance-students-socio-emotional-learning-mental-health-and-wellbeing-time-covid-19>

West Bengal, assembled on a platform called *Shiksha Alochana*. The platform was formed in 2016 by a group of primary school teachers who had led to transform their schools into active social institutions, which, apart from bringing in excellence in teaching-learning and all-round development of children, would inspire, accommodate and integrate local communities with the school. The individual initiatives were felt to be collectivized through a platform for exchanging views and gathering wider knowledge on school reform. Thus, the platform, registered in 2021 under the Societies Registration Act, has been active in two areas: (a) transforming individual schools, and (b) gathering and sharing knowledge on school education in particular and developmental issues in general. The latter resulted in a study report, *Primary Education in West Bengal: The Scope for Change*, written jointly by a group of school teachers and scholars from the higher education sector, on the state of primary education and the immediate tasks to improve it.⁷

The spread of Covid-19 and subsequent school closure in March 2020, we must admit, baffled us. With the astonishing spread of the virus followed by rumours, stigma, and twisting of social dynamics, we found ourselves in a state of terrible dilemma. With the fear of the virus and half-expectations of its going away soon, we suspended

7 Pratichi Institute and ShikshaAlochana (2018), *Primary Education in West Bengal: The Scope for Change*, Kolkata: Pratichi Institute and ShikshaAlochana

for a while our regular activities, except remaining in touch with each other over phone or internet devices. Nevertheless, while the fear started to subside, our expectations of the return of normalcy and opening of the schools after summer failed. This terrified us further: what would happen to the children? And, how shall we be able to perform our role, even assert our identity, without regular interactions with the children? The vagueness of public policies and lack of robust measures and clear guidelines about how to continue the educational processes added to the frustration.

The departmental initiatives of online teaching and supplying the children with worksheets through their parents during the monthly distribution of Mid-day Meals as substitutes were found to be inadequate. Firstly, only a tiny section of the children have access to devices for online education, not only in our respective neighbourhoods but also elsewhere. To quote a UNICEF report, “[T]he global reach of broadcast and online remote learning from over 100 countries find that, at minimum, 30 per cent of the world’s children were not reached by remote learning during the COVID-19 school closures due to a lack of country-level remote learning policies and/or a lack of household access to technology.”⁸ However, as our

8 UNICEF (2020) Covid-19: Are children able to continue learning during school closures? A global analysis of the potential reach of remote learning policies using data from 100 countries.<https://www.unicef.org/brazil/media/10006/file/remote-learning-factsheet.pdf>

experiences go, in the rural hamlets and urban squatter colonies in West Bengal the percentage of children having access to remote learning is much smaller than that of the globally reported rate. Secondly, since for most of the children enrolled in the public system, the school is the only place for learning and practising their lessons, providing worksheets to be completed at home do not offer an effective alternative to normal classroom activities. Two major findings of a UNICEF study are that, (a) “children who are recently out of school perform far behind children who continued to attend school”, and (b) “the foundational reading skills gap between these two groups widens with age.”⁹

The growing worries made many of the teachers think about developing possible ways to help children remain connected with learning.¹⁰ Since the departmental imperative prohibited any kind of assembly inside or outside the school so as to maintain physical distancing to check the spread of the virus, we had to think

9 UNICEF (2020) https://www.unicef-irc.org/publications/pdf/COVID-19_Effects_of_School_Closures_on_Foundational_Skills_and_Promising_Practices_for_Monitoring_and_Mitigating_Learning_Loss, https://www.unicef-irc.org/publications/pdf/COVID-19_Effects_of_School_Closures_on_Foundational_Skills_and_Promising_Practices_for_Monitoring_and_Mitigating_Learning_Loss.pdf

10 A reflection of this can be found in a recently published document, which has recorded the experiences of the teachers. See, Pratichi Trust and Tech Mahindra Foundation (2021) *Atimarite Sishusiksha*, Kolkata: Pratichi Trust

of alternative ways of keeping the students connected with the educational processes. Given the diverse geographical locations of the schools and the lack of transport facilities, all teachers did not have regular access to the areas their schools were located in. So, while some teachers could directly get involved in taking up the onus of continuing educational processes, some had to take help of the local youth as volunteers. Some had also found digital technologies somewhat appropriate. Some others could resort to only telephonic interactions. And yet, a vast number of students remained out of the ambit of education. The task of making good of the losses may look incredibly difficult, if not impossible, but it is the moral responsibility of all of us to make the impossible possible.

The report

Therefore, it is important to keep on record the efforts of teachers and others – however limited and inadequate they may be – to protect the educational dynamics from being completely stalled and preserve the experiences for future lessons. This report presents some of the efforts reported by our colleagues in a series of web-meetings we had, and also attended by members of the intelligentsia of West Bengal (more on this presently), during the pandemic. Many of them have also recorded their experiences in the form of notes. These were given a more organised shape by a committee of teachers. The write-up on the interventions undertaken during the

pandemic forms the first part of this report.

With this, it is perhaps more urgent to find out ways to remake the educational identity of the children – remedying not only the academic losses but also the socio-emotional injuries they have suffered. The urgency instructed us to (a) carry out a quick assessment of the competence level of the children so as to get some idea – however imprecise and incomplete – about the competence level of the children; and (b) chalk out a guideline – however rough – for the recuperation of the loss. The assessment was carried out mainly through observations, conversations and scrutiny of the worksheets distributed among young students. The results of the assessment give hope on the one hand that a good section of the children were somehow managing to be part of the educational processes in a more or less satisfactory way. But on the other hand, they add to the worry that about a quarter of them have faced huge academic loss, which requires urgent and effective measures to recover (see chapter 3 for details). To chalk out a broad guideline, we formed a committee to prepare a document consisting of the steps to be taken immediately, and after the opening of the schools. The prescriptions are provided in the second part of this work.

Apart from teaching and learning, we have been closely working with the local communities. It is their association that has made our efforts of transforming the schools – limited in reach as they are –

possible. So, it became a natural obligation of *Shiksha Alochana* to at least take note of their daily life – how they are living their life in this physically stressful, and more so in the economically and emotionally strenuous situation thrust upon them by the pandemic and some of the measures taken to keep its spread under control. So, we carried out an investigation, with some basic questions related to their survival, in some of the households in the neighborhoods our schools.

That children enrolled in the government run primary schools come mostly from socially and economically disadvantaged sections is a fact not unknown to the public. The knowledge about their vulnerability was further reinforced by the household level investigation – in both rural and urban areas – mentioned above. Small as the sample size was (369 households), the findings indicate the level of hardship of the common masses, most of whom are dependent on one or the other kind of manual work or low paid jobs. While nearly 30 per cent were day labourers, 20 percent were cultivators. A substantial section was involved in petty trading (16%). More importantly, six percent of the earning members in the households have been displaced from the job market. Even for many of those who retained or found some occupation, the earning fell (the average monthly income of the households has declined by 26 per cent – from Rs 7980 to Rs 5879).

Three of the 369 households have even fallen to the “no income” category (see Appendix tables for details). As a result, households have been forced to consume less. While the average consumption of cereals has come down by 14 per cent, consumptions of pulses, fish, meat, and vegetables have declined substantially (per cent figures being 22, 33, 44, and 24 respectively).

Children deserve equitable education as a matter of right. Their vulnerable social background, which was further devastated by the pandemic, has increased the social imperative of ensuring equitable education for all manifold. We, as education activists, understand that we have a dual role to play – to make substantial intervention to remedy the educational losses incurred by the children during the pandemic, and to participate in the movement for reorganizing the educational processes involving the larger society including the government.

Since its inception, *Shiksha Alochana* has been receiving robust intellectual support and generous practical help from the intellectuals and concerned citizens of West Bengal. With the initial collaborative support from the Pratichi Trust our social attachment has subsequently increased substantially. In fact, the report, *Primary Education in West Bengal: The Scope for Change* that we have mentioned above was a remarkable product of such a collaboration. We have been receiving encouragement and active support from many

academics, activists, and journalists. We have been interacting with them – through web-meetings – during the entire pandemic period, and have received many valuable suggestions on how to proceed to face the challenges mentioned above. The reader will easily find the impression of their thoughts in this report too.

Indeed, one can think of the possibility of a true Social Movement here. With teachers in the lead, and parents and citizens involved in a very big way, West Bengal can build a movement that may well become a game-changer not merely for education but even for society as a whole. Education for All has remained an objective unfulfilled for too long a time, which is a collective shame for the society. The crisis brought upon us by the pandemic challenges us to rise to the occasion and launch a collective movement to be the change that we want to see. It is only by learning and acting together that we can reclaim the pride that we have lost.

Short and somewhat incomplete as it is, the report may be useful for both public offices dealing with education and activists and others engaged in coming to terms with the challenges our children and society have been facing since the eruption of the Covid-19 and associated syndromes.

Chapter 2

Alternative processes of teaching-learning during the pandemic

The poet Walt Whitman (1819-1892) saw the future with characteristic optimism:

The future is no more uncertain than the present—
None has begun to think how certain the future is.
Of course all will be well.

How can one be so certain? Especially at the time of the pandemic with unprecedented spread, adding to the global population's sufferings perhaps in the wildest possible way, can one imagine a future where "all will be well"? Even if one is unsure about the wellness of the future, one is bound to reflect upon a different but related question: Uncertain as it is, what can we certainly do to make it less uncertain and relatively better than it is in the uncertain present? There is, in fact, no other way but to act upon what has been thrust upon us by the pandemic and subsequent policy measures, including the closure of schools, to resist the virus causing the pandemic. Inaction does make a difference, but for the worse.

While all of us became a victim of the baffling spread of the virus and temporarily surrendered to the events to take their own course, within no time the anxiety of our children losing their future overpowered the fear of the disease: What would happen to the children, whose learning is absolutely contingent on the functioning of the school system, especially, if not entirely, the public school system? What will happen to the majority of the children who have no support other than the school system to carry out their studies? As days went by, our worries started to grow into a nightmare and drove us to think about alternative ways of ensuring the continuation of children's learning activities. Aware as we were about our various limitations, especially the narrow reach (about 250 schools in the state where the total number of primary school institutions – including the Shishu Shiksha Kendras (SSKs) exceed 65,000), the guiding principle that 'doing as much as possible is better than not doing anything' inspired us to begin conversations, first with colleagues and friends and subsequently with others sharing and expressing their concerns. Along with numerous telephonic conversations, we held a series of online meetings – both internal (among colleagues) and broad-based (with others interested and involved in the field of education). The conversations made a breakthrough as we could learn from our colleagues and others about the various ways they had already adopted to keep educational practices of the children alive.

Our areas of work were diverse in nature: Some were inaccessible owing to the lockdown rules; some had very poor access to telephone, let alone internet; some had reasonably wide-open spaces for carrying out in-person teaching-learning activities maintaining the rules of physical distancing laid down by the Health Department, but others had no space at all; while some of the teachers live near their respective schools, others live in faraway places and commute to their workplaces daily; some areas had resources in the forms of educated youths who could volunteer to help carry out the teaching-learning activities—in however limited a manner—but others lacked such support, which is very crucial. The diversity of the settings invariably led to the education activists designing and applying multiple ways of alternative teaching-learning processes. They included (a) in-person interactions: individually by visiting the homes of the children, and in small groups in the localities; developing local resources in the form of local educated youths; and guiding the parents—and private tutors in cases—about the lessons to introduce to their wards; and (b) teaching-learning from a distance: telephonic conversations and WhatsApp messages and video meetings; developing and sharing with the children teaching materials, including texts, graphics, cartoons, videos, and similar pedagogic tools; other technology based learning, such as through local TV channels and YouTube; and in many cases (see **Appendix**

Table 1 for a select list of schools and modes adopted by them).

We have been trying to enhance the reach and improve the quality of activities through discussions, and in one such discussion, in June 2021, we received some very valuable suggestions from many quarters in the society, the main focus of which was to involve the larger society, including parents, educated youths, NGOs, and local private tutors to build up local level volunteers to help the children continue their academic activities (see **Box 1**). Some of us, especially in Murshidabad and Nadia, have taken up such initiatives with varying degree of success – from marginal to satisfactory. We now present in brief some examples of the activities.

In-person teaching-learning

There was no single locality where children did not appear impatient about joining the school. They asked us, either over the phone or in-person when they chanced upon to meet us during the monthly distribution of dry ration, “When will our schools open? We want to be back to the school.”

Although the grammarian and a bestselling author N M Gwynne found the internet-based teaching so remarkable that, “within seconds of a class starting, it is as though we are in the same classroom together,”¹¹ his experiences were with (a) elderly students, and his

11 Gwynne, NM (2015), *Gwynne's Grammar: The Ultimate Introduction to Grammar and the Writing of Good English*, New York: Alfred A Knopf, p. ix

teaching was confined only to one– though very important– area of learning, namely grammar, and (b) his students apparently did not have to worry about internet-based facilities. But our situation was completely different because of very limited access to internet and the severely restricted purchasing power of our students and their families, all the more so because of the pandemic and economic collapse. The authors of the National Education Policy 2020, though, seem quite excited about digital modes of teaching and dream of a digital future of our education system.¹²

We cannot speculate about the future, but at the given point of time the notion that there is no substitute of in-person teaching and learning, at least at the primary level, is hardly disputed by any. Based on this common understanding, some of us tried to keep in-person contact with the children and help them carry on their academic works, of course without violating the health norms laid down by the Health Department. The in-person contacts depended

12 “Once internet-connected smart phones or tablets are available in all homes and/or schools, online apps with quizzes, competitions, assessments, enrichment materials, and online communities for shared interests will be developed, and will work to enhance all the aforementioned initiatives, as group activities for students with appropriate supervision of parents and teachers. Schools will develop smart classrooms, in a phased manner, for using digital pedagogy and thereby enriching the teaching-learning process with online resources and collaborations.” See, Government of India (2020), *National Education Policy 2020*, Ministry of Human Resource Development, https://www.education.gov.in/sites/upload_files/mhrd/files/NEP_Final_English_0.pdf, p. 20

upon certain realities: Interest of the concerned teachers, regular access to the localities, absence of political and social hindrances in the localities, availability of space to carry out teaching-learning in small groups safely, the prevalent rate of infection in the particular locality, and so on. For example, teachers in some of the schools have been very dedicated toward their mission of continuously improving the quality of schooling (not just academic excellence, but also other components like environment, hygiene, sports, and cultural and literary activities), and being popular with children and parents, they had the added advantage of garnering full support of the local communities. With local help, they could manage to find spaces for carrying out the activities in small groups. Certainly, the initiatives were usually favoured by a little bit of luck, and yet, the task was not easy. To quote a teacher of Dakshin Dinajpur:

We were lucky that the intensity of the disease was low and people in the area were less panicked than what was the case elsewhere. Also, our residential advantage—living in the surrounding areas—added to our initiatives. Even then, it was not very easy. One has to sub-divide the classes into several small fractions to maintain health norms. So, it required more time than what used to be in a normal situation, when you can carry on the activities with a large group of students. Nevertheless, given the tremendous interest of the children and encouragement of the local communities, we could manage to resist



Chalaman Pathshala - Mobile School by University Students at Santiniketan

much of the academic losses of the children in such a way that they would not find it much difficult to catch up with the normally taught syllabus after the schools resume.

There is no denying the fact that the level of dedication among teachers was skewed, and the absence of motivation to think clearly and challengingly was conspicuous among many. One cannot also overlook the fact that despite being very sincere and remarkably well-intended—even some of them achieved the philosophical height of “ignoring the mundane sufferings” as advised by the *Mahabharata*,¹³—many of the teachers could not maintain the in-person teaching-learning activities unhindered. There appeared several problems, such as the spread of the infection that terrorized the population and many areas ran out of luck rapidly. Again, some of the teachers lived in faraway places and could not organize in-person open-air classes.

In those cases, they had to find alternatives to in-person teaching and learning by taking the help of the local educated youths, most of whom were their ex-students. In some cases the private tutors in the localities (many of whom became unemployed as parents could not afford the fees) were requested to volunteer to help in carrying on teaching-learning activities.

13 *The Mahabharata*, Anushasan Parva, 75:18

To quote another teacher of Purba Medinipur:

It was bad that we lived in places from where it was impossible to commute daily to our respective school areas. On the one hand, there was no public transport available (due to lockdown), and on the other, there were restrictions on movement even by one's own vehicle. So, we approached our ex-students to act on our behalf. It is true that they did not have the required training and ability to replace the regular teachers, but what they could do was to keep the lamp burning. They met the young children regularly and encouraged them to keep up studies, read for them some lessons and asked questions, and gave some tasks. Also, they supervised the filling up of the worksheets distributed to the children through their parents during the monthly distribution of dry ration. This way they formed a huge support base for the continuation of the academic activities of the primary level children. Also, we found some private tutors who agreed to help the children, free of cost. Some of the parents had been continuing to provide paid private tutors, whom we contacted to join the battle to fight the darkness of ignorance looming large. Thankfully, many of them readily agreed to join the social enterprise.

As mentioned above, in one of our consultancy meetings, we received a suggestion to expand the community level involvements to carry on the teaching-learning process. The suggestions underscored that in such an abnormal situation it was a socially emerged necessity to organise a wider social movement to survive

the educational prospect of the children. Hence, we should take up an initiative to develop local level volunteer groups. The suggestions are paraphrased and summarised in box 1.

Box 1. PROPOSED GUIDELINES FOR VOLUNTEER TEACHERS

1. The main partners of this arrangement are the parents and local level volunteers. Teachers from the respective schools will mediate the arrangement. But while they can and must advise the volunteers and parents, the teachers will not, however, be responsible for running the programme. Their role in running this alternative program will be limited to that of an advisory authority. The onus of actually carrying out the programme will be on the local volunteers who join of their own motivation and commitment.
2. Before beginning the process, it is important to introduce the parents and volunteers to each other, and ensure that each party has the other's trust. They should share contact details. Teachers may facilitate this coordination.
3. Names and symbols of political parties must not be used. Those who join this process will come as social volunteers.
4. There will be no monetary transaction of any sort, direct or indirect. Those who earn their living as private tutors may join the initiative as volunteers, but their joining will not be conditional of any promise of sending the children to them in future for paid lessons.
5. Covid protocols and all other health norms must be strictly maintained. The number of students will be limited by the available space, so as to allow for sanitization and physical distancing. Unless impossible, classes should be organized in open grounds or spaces like verandahs, community places, and so on.

6. The volunteers will be given some basic guidelines on handling and interacting with the children. There must be no corporal punishment, threats or objectionable comments. If the children need to be disciplined, that must be done with restraint, approaching the parents if required.

It is equally unnecessary to offer the children food or gifts. They can be supplied with learning materials and equipment (or if the situation demands, other support), if the volunteers can afford it; but it would be better to route such support through the teachers or the community, rather than give it as personal donation.

Our colleagues have been working in some areas of Murshidabad, North 24 Parganas, Nadia, and Dakshin Dinajpur to realize this proposal and have achieved some success, and a few thousand students have already been reached through such initiatives. Many other individuals and organisations have been involved in similar socially volunteered educational activities. Perhaps there is enough scope of sharing and assimilating all the plural experiences to advance the educational processes – not only during the pandemic, but also in regular situations, which we all expect to be back soon.

Teaching-learning from distance

The situation, however, was uneven, and many were not privileged enough to maintain in-person contact with the children. This made them devise other modes of teaching by using smartphones, ordinary phones, and the distribution of lessons and worksheets

through parents. For example, in an area in Jalpaiguri, teachers were “managing really well. Students were assembling in small groups in the hamlets. Although it was much time-consuming, we did not mind and continued the classes in small groups.” However, Nature had other plans. Some of the members of the local community caught the virus, and one of them succumbed to the illness. Fear grasped the locality, and they had to stop the open-air classes.

It was very frustrating, and for the time being, we lost hope. Then, we started to find some ways to keep the academic processes alive. Parents in the locality were poor, and only a few had smartphones. Many did not have even an ordinary phone. Even those who had a smartphone could not use it for video conversations owing to the limited data they could purchase. Some of the parents failed to arrange money to buy talk-time for their ordinary phones. It was really very difficult. So, we organized occasional video sessions, and telephonic conversations with the children, that too in groups. While this added some energy to the effort, it required more, which we tried to provide partly by distributing specially prepared lessons and worksheets. Far from being perfect though, this has been helping the students to be in touch with the letters and numbers and some of the lessons.

Some areas, however, were a bit luckier. As we hear from a teacher from Purba Medinipur, who, with her colleagues, could



Children performing in a function organised by local community and teachers

combine a number of resources to keep up the learning processes of the children. In her words:

As soon as the schools were closed in March 2020, I started thinking about the possible ways to carry out teaching and learning. Some of the children were fortunate enough to have smartphones at their disposal – at least for some time in the day. So, we collected their numbers and divided them into five groups for five standards (1-5) and sent them recorded lessons. Besides, we started sending them some audio-visuals collected from YouTube, Facebook, and other sources. Subsequently, we visited their homes and circulated the activity tasks (for all) and formative evaluation sheets (for the children of standards 3-5), and merit test question papers (for all). With those who did not have a smartphone but possessed an ordinary phone or could access one in the neighbourhood, we made long telephonic conversations. However, as these proved to be inadequate, we decided to visit their homes, especially those without access to smartphones, and helped them catch up on the lessons. Often we arranged classes in open fields, maintaining the health regulations. This way we could publish the results. Also, we could organize, though in very limited ways, some functions. In a word, we have been able to keep close contact with the children and their parents and manage to avert the academic and socio-emotional losses of the children – at least to some extent.

Given below is a sample of digitally prepared lessons:

Table 1. Sample digital lessons

Standard	Subject	Description
1	Bengali and English	1. Vowel signs 2. Colours; 3. Let us make words (এসো শব্দ বানাই) 4. Practice spelling and reading English
1	English	1. Body parts; 2. The use of ‘May I...’; 3. The use of ‘I am...’
1	Arithmetic	1.Subtraction
1	Environmental studies	1.Making mats from discarded plastic bags to stop plastic pollution.
1		1) Revision lessons
2	Bengali and English	1.Bengali Rhyme (বারোমেসে) and Season activity
2	English	1) Seasons; 2) Traffic Signals; 3) Body Parts and Sense Organs 4) Use of Capital letters and vowels; 5) Uses of ‘ May I...’; 6) Singular and Plural; 7) Uses of This and That
3	English	1) Lesson – 1 (The Willy Followers); 2) Making Tiger Mask (Craft-works after the class); 3. Lesson 2 (Arrival meeting); 4, My House (activity – 6) discussion about Prepositions; 5) Sounds of vowels; 6) Article; activity; 7) Revision lessons

The number of students enrolled in a school seemed to have made a big difference. Since high enrolment in schools tended to mean more diverse background of the students, their ability to access online teaching

appeared to be varied. While some students could afford internet connections and access online programs with relative ease, some could not even afford to use an ordinary mobile phone. For example, a colleague from South 24 Parganas had more than 150 students. A few had smartphones, and we sent to their phones WhatsApp messages containing videos and other materials. “Alas, despite their willingness to share the materials with others, it was simply impossible to reach even a fraction of students.” In contrast, another colleague from Nadia could manage to carry out, to a substantial extent, learning activities among children through WhatsApp. Her students too came from poor backgrounds, and “there were only 3-4 smartphones available in the community, and children could access them only when the elder members came back home from work. Despite the limitation, we could at least manage to reach almost all of them because the number was small – only 30.”

Distribution of sheets prepared for the students to work on and return to the teachers through their parents who assembled in the schools to collect dry ration was carried out in all the schools engaged with in this report. In some of the cases the sheets were prepared imaginatively. They did not contain only the lessons given in the textbooks, but were made interesting by using pictures and stories. Yet, this mode was useful enough to compensate for only a fraction of the academic loss incurred. One major problem involving the worksheets

was that they were distributed monthly, making it hard for both students and teachers to work with. The second problem was a very common one that had continued through the ages: lack of assistance at home. While many of the households did not have a single person to assist the children in their studies, others complained that owing to the loss of income during the lockdown they failed to arrange money to pay private tutors. Residents of West Bengal know very well how overarching the practice of paid private tuition is – despite the disputability about the effectiveness of the paid out-of-school teaching. In Amartya Sen’s words, private tuition was an artificially created necessity. The subject has attracted much debate and discussions, particularly after the publication of the Pratichi Trust’s study reports on primary education, where Professor Sen has dealt with the issue *inter alia* others at some length.¹⁴

Some innovations

The shortcomings of the process involving distribution of worksheets were somewhat remedied through supplementations. Some of our colleagues have been engaged in preparing digital materials, including short films, storytelling, and lesson-based videos, and have gradually

14 See, Sen A (2002), “Introduction”, in Rana K, A Rafique and A Sengupta, *Pratichi Education Report I*, Delhi: TLM Books in association with the Pratichi Trust, and also Sen, A (2009), “Introduction”, in Rana K, S Sen, M Sarkar, and P Halder, *Pratichi Education II*, Delhi: Pratichi Trust

improved those following the inputs received from both the children, and colleagues and others who had participated in our regular online discussions. A report from North 24 Pargans bears testimony to the endeavours of technology-supported teaching-learning activities:

Most of our schools are located in the hinterlands. Households are socio-economically disadvantaged who cannot even imagine online interaction through smartphones or other such internet-based devices. Since most of us are not from the localities surrounding the schools, it was not possible for us to be present in person regularly. The adversity led us to devise certain mechanisms to help the students continue their studies. We recalled our classroom experiences of how eager the children were to read comic books and watch cartoon movies. So, we started preparing small cartoon videos. We also prepared scripts of short plays. These were sent to the parents' phone numbers who followed up by making the children take part in the plays and video-recorded those to send us back the plays. We then edited the stuff and uploaded them on a YouTube channel. The contents of the videos included materials that were both entertaining and lesson oriented. Despite limited access to smartphones or other internet-based devices, these contents could be widely circulated by the local communities. They used the limited number of phones and other devices in turn where children could watch them in small groups. Apart from helping the children study their lessons, the videos played a major role in keeping

them connected with the academic processes. The videos were in addition to the worksheets supplied to them through their parents. A comparison between the initial period and the period when videos were supplied showed a very positive difference in the performance of the children in terms of exercising on the worksheets. Inadequate as the practices were—we have reason to believe that nothing can fully substitute for in-person teaching and learning—these materials somehow kept the processes of learning going. The opportunity of the children to take part in preparing the videos revitalized their enthusiasm. We present below brief descriptions of select videos.

Table 2. Brief description of select plays and cartoons prepared by and for the children

Standard	Title of the short videos	Contents
Pre-primary to 4	Three of them and the king of the ghosts (ওরা তিনজন ও ভুতের রাজা)	Children's helplessness during the lock-down
	The uncle who lives on the tree tells tales (গল্প বলেন গেছো জ্যাঠা)	Importance of eating vegetables; and some medicinal plants
	Let us explore the distant places(চলো যাই দূরে চলে আসি ঘুরে)	Architectures, sculptures, structures, museums.
	On the other side of the blue sky (নীল আকাশের ওই পারে)	The solar system, exploring the planet system, and our country
2	Tagore in <i>Sabajpath</i> – the book (সহজ পাঠে রবীঠাকুর)	Select lessons from the <i>Sabajpath</i> , Part 2

In some areas teachers have been using local TV channels to carry on academic activities. A colleague from Bankura has been using these modes very successfully and has inspired others, especially in Purba Medinipur.

In some exceptional cases teachers could use the interactive internet platforms, like Google Meet, where many students could be addressed and heard at a time, making it a kind of a virtual classroom. The reason for such limited facilities was obvious: non-availability of desktop or laptop computers or other devices with large screens. Despite the constraint, some colleagues could create artificial classroom situations by using such platforms, by following simple (when available) processes (see box 2).

Box 2. Creating virtual classroom through internet-based meeting platforms

1. Collect the PDF files of all the textbooks (many of them are available on the website of the WBPPE; those which are not available can be scanned and converted to PDF);
2. Convert the PDF into JPEG (by using a converter offered by Google and others); this can also be done by taking photograph of the pages with a smartphone camera;
3. Open the pages on desktop or laptop;
4. Show the pages one by one using “share screen” on any internet-based meeting facility; children can directly see the pages on their screen (smartphone or computer);
5. Add a pen-tablet with the laptop; using this one can write on the pages shown on the screen; send pdf copies of what has been written on the pages; this apart, digital white board can also be used to write on.



In-person teaching-learning maintaining health norms

To keep the educational processes alive some of the teachers have published school magazine containing writings and drawings of the children.

Social involvements

The pandemic has made many of the teachers involved in several social activities, including reaching out to the distressed people (jobless, for example) with food and other support. At least in one area in Murshidabad teachers successfully carried out a Mothers' Literacy programme among 35 mothers. The initiative was essentially taken by the mothers who approached us to help, which we most happily did. They thought improving their own literacy status would be useful for their children's education. Parents, especially mothers were found to be anxious about their children's educational prospect – “we want them to acquire education at any cost”, was echoed across the state.

A very encouraging feature noticed during the pandemic time was the concern of the general public in some areas regarding children's education. We are aware of some such initiatives across the state. For example, Liver Foundation, West Bengal has started a programme called, *Svanirbhar Siksha Udyog*, involving the self-help groups.¹⁵ *Shiksha Alochana* did not have the scope to document those citizens' initiatives – though it could be very useful for both

15 See for details, <http://www.liverfoundation.in/>

policy reorientation and social inspiration – we give here our readers a glimpse of one such initiative taken up by a group of students in Santiniketan. The university students have been facilitating a group of sixty very underprivileged students – living in the slums by the railway line and the canal. As a student volunteer told us:

Parents and children alike are so enthusiastic about this initiative. They assemble at certain corners of the slums designated to be the make-shift classrooms much before we arrive. They have none to assist at home, and none of the parents have the ability to pay for private tuition. The little support we could provide makes a big difference, since children are connected to their studies. We, as students, find our volunteering fulfilling.¹⁶

The example, we have reason to believe, is not an isolated one. Several such initiatives are going on.

The glimpses of the experiences of teaching-learning activities facilitated by teachers and local communities, while showing the limitations of alternative methods, offered a number of new ways and means, which not only helped in keeping the academic processes survive—though with limited geographical reach—but also offered a range of innovations which could substantially supplement regular school processes when they are resumed. With this, the processes

16 Interested readers may contact Meghna Banerjee (+91-8158965963) to know the details.

taken up point toward the unavoidably central role to be played by the teachers – be it during a pandemic or in a normal situation. Human morality, on the one hand, and systemic arrangements, on the other, makes it mandatory for teachers to accept the challenge of delivery of education in the most equitable way; they can hardly resort to inaction and avert their responsibilities, however difficult the situation may be. Also, the experiences underscore the centrality of decentralised educational processes. While each school is embedded in a different socio-economic setting, each child has her special interest and is endowed with her own psychological make-up. To make our educational delivery equitable, which should be of utmost priority in the nation's planning, it is imperative that we make the system plural, with a certain level of local autonomy to choose the right path of school functioning. However, what is most important at this stage is to think collectively to find ways and forms of re-opening schools and resuming education in full force.

In-person teaching-learning maintaining health norms



Chapter 3

Challenges ahead and way forward

The objective reality

The positive experiences narrated in the previous section may, however, need to be seen in the light of possibilities rather than allowing them to make us complacent. The task of recovering from the damage done to education in general, and primary education in particular, is indeed enormous. From a quick assessment of a small fraction of primary students, we have found that of 7204 students of standards 1-5, only 44 per cent appeared to have satisfactory levels of competence (see Table 3.1 below). We are using the term ‘satisfactory’ liberally, since the assessment did not follow a rigorous methodology. Owing to the unusual nature of the situation thrust upon us by the pandemic on the one hand and lack of time and resources on the other, the assessment was conducted on the basis of observations and conversations and examining the worksheets – a partially followed CCE (continuous and comprehensive evaluation) method. Despite the discounts made in the assessment, 24 per cent of the children appeared to have very poor level of competence – as poor as not being able to read and write in many cases. The corresponding figure for average level of

competence was 32 per cent. While the small number of students covered within the assessment and the methodological weaknesses (students were selected according to their availability rather than being statistically chosen) make the findings only indicative, their conformity with public perception, reported in print and electronic media, social media, and also in verbal circulation, provide an idea of the graveness of the situation.

**Table 3.1. Primary Students' Level of Learning in Select Areas of West Bengal
(N= 7204)**

Subjects	Levels			Total
	Satisfactory	Average	Very poor	
First Language	45.9	30.6	23.4	100
Arithmetic	41.7	33.2	25	100
English	40.6	32.5	27	100
Environmental studies	47.8	30.1	22.1	100
Average	44	32	24	100

Note: Readers may see the standard-wise and district-wise details in the appendix.

As the reader can see, the distribution of competence is quite similar across subjects. Also, we have learnt from the assessment that more than a quarter of the students we could contact did not receive

any help from teachers or others and were almost disconnected from academic activities (see Table 3.2). The detachment—or exclusion—of a certain section of students from the arena of education has certainly made the task even more difficult.

Table 3.2. Status of receiving any academic help from teachers or others (N=7204)

Status	Percentage
Received	72
Not received	28

One is justified in asking, “Is it possible to recover the loss? Is it possible that those who have lost contact with letters and numbers could get on to the bus?” Our experiences, however, provide a suggestion in the affirmative. When schooling was regular, many of us had students with different kinds of learning difficulties, which were dealt with by adopting various innovative ways.

Underachievement of primary school children in West Bengal—and in the country as a whole—is not a new phenomenon. A section of children, hailing from disadvantaged social and economic backgrounds, continued to be excluded from the ambit of learning, despite being able to enter the school campus and classroom. Two decades ago Professor Amartya Sen had rebuked the state and society: “we may well ask: what, then, do they [children from



Local community maintains the school garden during the closure

underprivileged background and not assisted by paid private tutors] learn in school?”¹⁷ A vicious cycle of accusation was unleashed: primary teachers accused parents and ICDS centres, secondary school teachers accused primary schools, higher secondary school teachers accused secondary schools, and so on. Nevertheless, a section of teachers asked themselves: “Why should the child be punished for a systemic fault? Why should she not be given the opportunity to learn?” The morally powerful and disturbing question made them adopt certain innovative methods. Notwithstanding the limitation of the extent of such initiatives, the results they yielded can be very useful in coming to terms with the problem of underachievement during the pandemic. We briefly share below some of the examples. The first one is from our previous report (readers can find several others in that report, and in some other works).¹⁸

The newly joined teacher [in a school in Dakshin Dinajpur] was utterly confused: what to do here? Children of standard 4 did not learn the alphabet...For him, the first challenge was to make sure that children attended the school on a regular basis. Ensuring attendance required at least two things: children find the school interesting; and parents find it worthwhile to send their children to

17 Sen A (2002), *op*.

18 Pratichi Institute and ShikshaAlochana (2018), Primary Education in West Bengal: The Scope for Change, Kolkata: Pratichi Institute and ShikshaAlochana; Rana K, S Sen, M Sarkar, and P Halder(2009)*Pratichi Education II*, Delhi: Pratichi Trust; Pal P (2014), *SchoolerManey*, Kolkata: Pratichi Trust

school....It was a series of outside-the-classroom activities – from simple conversations to encouraging singing and playing football – that established a bonding between the children and the teacher....It required additional efforts...he had to come to school much earlier than the schedule and leave much later than the official closure of the school and taught the children in batches. But the gap was so wide that his efforts fell shorter than required...Adjacent to the school there was a club, where he found a few of the members with basic ability of reading and writing. A request from the teacher to volunteer to help in ensuring children's out of school studies... was welcomed by the members. ...The system was developed in such a way that aside from classroom teaching and learning space was created to involve children in a number of activities – drawing, singing and dancing, sports, drama, cleaning the school ground and classrooms, and so on...Not very slowly, the school took a completely different shape. Inability of reading, writing and numerical operations is a thing of the past.

While news of the initiatives of the primary school teachers have, to some extent, reached the general public, efforts of high school teachers have been less known. But, such experiences can potentially add a lot to encourage the possibility of making good the academic losses of the children during the pandemic and also to find newer ways and means to take the task forward.

The first one is from Malda, a district marked with educational

disadvantage and deficiency. Let us hear the story from an ex-head teacher:

It was in 2012 when the implementation of the Right to Education Act 2009 made us change the admission rules. So far, we had been enrolling students through an entrance test, which was found to be contrary to the law. This made it impossible to screen the students according to their level of competence. Again, with the general enhancement in enrolment, huge number of students appeared to be enrolled, and this made our task terribly difficult. So, we had to enrol 154 students in standard five. The number was 54 more than what was in the previous year. Our trouble was multiplied when we found through a quick test after the admission that 77 of the total enrolled children never learnt the letters or numbers. We could have easily escaped by not paying any heed to their level of competence and letting them take the “normal” course of dropping out at a higher stage. But, there was a question: “why should these children suffer because (of) the wrongdoing of others? After all, we are teachers for whom any student is a student, irrespective of her level of competence. Why cannot we think something anew so as to recover the losses thrust upon them?” This made us adopt a new method: beginning a separate, but temporary, section for the poor learners so as to lift up their competence level. Believe me, it worked wonder and within three to six months all the 77 children could make themselves ready to sit with their peers in the regular sections. I have never felt so fulfilled in my entire teaching life. Our school



Local volunteers using lesson videos prepared by teachers

earned the name because of the selection procedure that eliminated the poor learners, but it was only this time that our school could rectify a social wrong of keeping (a) section of children outside the ambit of learning.

How remedial classes could make good the losses of four years (standard 1-4) in just three to six months was explained by the experience of another high school teacher from Birbhum :

It became a favourite pastime of certain section teachers to accuse the “no-detention” norm, and the Right to Education Act 2009. These, they thought, made the primary school teachers lazy as students could get enrolled in standard five without learning anything. It was irritating, I found such attitudes harmful to the dignity of any teacher. Why should a teacher take a route of escapism? Why can’t we act as members of a community involved in one of the most virtuous act? Are not we the torch-bearers of Tagore and Gandhi? The disturbance of mind made me approach the head teacher to assign me the English class of standard 5. I was for a moment, I must admit, at the verge of repentance. But then somehow I managed to gather some courage. First, I spent about a week talking with them, one by one, I listened to their stories, their daily lives, etc, and began the lessons rather slowly, apparently casually. What I discovered in no time that the task was not as difficult as has been imagined and much publicised. It was true that they had not grown with the letters or numbers, but their mind did not stop growing. It had grown as

spaciously as to pick up the lost lessons within a very short time. What was needed was the friendliness – between the students and the teacher.

We know that individual trees do not make the forest, but what we must know is that we cannot imagine the forest without the individual trees. Despite the risk of generalising particular experiences, we must, therefore, draw inspiration and useful clues from these experiences to face the challenge of academic losses thrust upon the children. Given the near certainty of delayed resumption of regular teaching-learning process after the reopening of the schools, we must think of novel ways to help children pick up lost lessons and rejuvenate the school system. From this realization we began the exercise of involving a series of discussions among teachers and others and have prepared a broad programme of action. The draft has been prepared keeping in mind the plurality of school and social situations, and individual teachers and activists can use it by modifying it according to their specific contexts. Further exercises, we believe, will make the programme more robust and enhance its applicability.

Possible actions for resuming the schooling processes

1. Preparing the ground: The first task is to prepare the ground for resuming school in person. This requires wide-ranging discussions at various levels. “Although a man be wys himself, yit is the wisdom

more of twelve”, wrote John Gower in his *Confessio Amantis* in 1390.¹⁹ The statement is as relevant today as it was seven centuries ago: there is no alternative to collective wisdom. So, first, the government must initiate a discussion involving epidemiologists, virologists, public health specialists, educationists, and activists. The discussion should percolate down to the local levels involving teachers, activists, and local communities, and also students. The discussions will aim to find ways to open the schools without making any compromise with the health risk. Given the immense variations in the local situations the discussions cannot but add priority to a decentralised mechanism.

2. Preparing the schools: Since schools have effectively been closed, except occasionally opening for the distribution of dry ration, it is urgent that they be cleaned and properly sanitized. They also have to be jointly inspected by public health workers, teachers, and local communities who may suggest further modification, such as reorganization of classes. For example, in a school with high enrolments, they may suggest a routine that will assign classes on alternate days so as to make enough room to maintain physical distancing. They will explore ways of utilising to the optimum the school premises so that classes can be held, as much as possible, in the open.

19 Cited in, John, Peter (2011), *Conversation: And the Reception of David Hume*, Edinburgh: The Institute for Advanced Studies in the Humanities, The University of Edinburgh.



Women participants of a literacy programme carried out by teachers during closure

3. Bringing students back to school: One major task of the teachers will be to bring the students back to school. This can only be done by being connected with the local communities, including parents and others, by different means – from convening meetings at school to visiting the hamlets and homes. Experiences from our own initiatives and other efforts, mentioned in Chapter 2, show that it is possible to build teams of local volunteers to help bring all students back to school and also assist in the academic processes.
4. Resuming the Mid-day Meals: The cooked Mid-day Meal served to the children has had many positive impacts on the school system as a whole.²⁰ Nevertheless, the restriction imposed on economic mobility of the population has brought back one of the central relevance of the hot cooked meals in the school – nutritional supplement. Recent reports on poor, and declining, nutritional status of the children²¹

20 Dreze Jean and AparajitaGoel (2003), “Future of Mid-Day Meals”, Economic and Political Weekly, 38(44); SethiBishnupada (2003) *Mid-day Meal Programme and Its Impact in Improving Enrolment: A study in respect of Rayagada district of Orissa*; Office of the District Magistrate, Raygada;GoWB& UNICEF (2003), *A Report on the Cooked Mid-day Meal Programme in West Bengal*, UNICEF, Kolkata (mimeo); GoWB (2003): *Impact of the Cooked Mid-day Meal Programme in Murshidabad District : A study by District Administration, Murshidabad*, Office of the District Magistrate, Murshidabad; Rana K (2005) “The Possibilities of Mid-day Meal Programme in West Bengal”, paper presented at the workshop on “West Bengal: Challenges and Choices”, organized by the Centre for Social Sciences, Calcutta, on 27 and 28 July 2004.

21 IIPS (2020), National Family Health Survey – 5 (2019-20), Mumbai: International Institute of Population Sciences

have added much urgency to the resumption of the cooked Mid-day Meal programme, which has been stopped for more than one and half years in schools. Household level collected under this study showed that owing to loss of work (6%), and fall in wage and other sources of income households have faced a sharp (30%) decline in monthly income of the households (see Appendix tables 3.2 and 3.3).

5. Preparing for lessons: It may not be possible to resume classes instantly. Children will be coming to school after a long, unusual, and forced break. They need to be provided with a setting that allows them enough room to acclimatize to the situation. One most important task for teachers will be to listen to the children individually. We may remember the story of *Totto Chan*, the so-called unmindful girl who was expelled from several schools, and finally it was the headmaster Sosaku Kobayashi who changed her life only by listening to her. He was able to do so because “he believed all children are born with an innate good nature”, and his “aim was to uncover their ‘good nature’ and develop it, so that the children would grow into people with individuality.”²² Teachers have to prepare themselves in a newer way to discover children in their full potential.

A. Beginning the lessons: Classes should be organised in a manner that does not let the children feel that they have been away for long. They have to be made acquainted with the school in

22 Tetsuko Kuroyanagi (1996), *Totto Chan: The Little Girl at the Window*, Translated by Dorothy Britton, Tokyo: Kodansha International.

a friendly way, without being burdened with workload. Given the gap in schooling, it is centrally important to know the levels of competence of each student, and hence, they have to be assessed through a baseline exercise, which could be called Minimum Most Essential Learning Outcomes (MMELO). We propose a broad assessment plan in draft form, which could be suitably adopted by different teachers according to their specific contexts. The exercise will help identify the level of competence of individual students and teachers can prepare remedial plans according to each child's specific level and need.

B. The proposed Minimum Most Essential Learning Outcomes (MMELO)

Standard 1 (class of 2022):

- i. Concepts of vowels and consonants with their pronunciation followed by developing competence of writing;
- ii. Concept of numbers and competence of writing them;
- iii. Recognising the colours;
- iv. Rhymes;
- v. Introducing the English alphabets;
- vi. Introducing the Arabic numerals.

C. Standard 2 (class of 2022):

- i. Identifying and using the vowel signs;
- ii. Formation and writing of small words;
- iii. Formation of small sentences;

- iv. Learning and writing the numbers from 0-100;
- v. Concept of place value;
- vi. Addition, subtraction, and multiplication through problem solving;
- vii. Concept of English alphabets;
- vii. Colours, parts of body, days of week, month of year in first language and English.

D. Standard 3 (class of 2022):

First Language

- i. Concept of the conjunctives;
- ii. Analysing the alphabet;
- iii. Using the conjunctives;
- iv. Making sentences

English

- i. Basic idea of parts of speech;
- ii. Making sentences;
- iii. Counting numbers and ability to write both in numbers and words;

Arithmetic

- i. Concept of smallest and largest numbers;
- ii. Addition, subtraction, multiplication, and introduction with division;
- iii. Multiplication tables;
- iv. Concept of coins and notes;
- v. Straight lines and curves;

vi. Geometric formations.

E. Standard 4 (class of 2022)

First Language

- i. Thoroughness of concept of the conjunctives;
- ii. Reading and understanding complex sentences;
- iii. Reading and writing short paragraphs with punctuations, and reading the questions and write the answers;
- iv. Writing down unknown words heard for the first time;
- v. Knowing clearly about the sounds, alphabets, and letters.

English

- i. Using simple and contextual sentences to describe familiar objects;
- ii. Knowing verbs and their transforms;
- iii. Organise simple ideas in written form with proper punctuation marks;

Arithmetic

- i. Three digit number and performing all the four basic functions (add, subtract, multiply, and divide);
- ii. Different geometric formations;
- iii. Concept of odd and even numbers;
- iv. Conditions of divisibility;
- v. Reading the clock; solving sums related to time;
- vi. Concept of the average;
- vii. Using first bracket; Concept of simplification.

F. Standard 5 (class of 2022)

First language

- i. Reading different texts and writing answers to the text based questions
- ii. Writing short paragraphs using simple and complex sentences to express their minds;
- iii. Knowing in details the vowel and consonant sounds;

English

- i. Using proper nouns;
- ii. Reading skills and writing paragraphs;
- iii. Skills to use prepositions, adverbs, etc.
- iv. Use of tense.

Arithmetic

- i. Concept of four digit numbers;
- ii. Performing the four basic numerical function through problem-solving;
- iii. From total to average and *vice versa*;
- iv. Knowing the different units of measure;
- v. Fraction and decimal fraction;
- vi. Multiplier and factor;
- vii. Prime number and composite number;
- viii. Geometric figures;
- ix. Determining the area;
- x. Solving simple sums.

We have not included Environmental Studies in the proposed MMELO as once students are proficient in Language and Arithmetic, it will not be very difficult for them to cover gaps in Environmental Studies. Also, students' performance in Environmental Studies was found to be somewhat better than that in Language and Arithmetic. Nevertheless, teachers can easily include it in their respective assessment exercises.

A Collective Responsibility

It is a collective responsibility, of both government and society, to come to terms with a situation that has threatened the country by causing enormous harm to the educational prospects of children. The government may have a shortage of resources but that should not deter it from gathering the will power to face the challenge, especially when many of the social segments are more than ready to come together to carry forward an initiative to save the fate of the children. Back in 1970, Professor Amartya Sen diagnosed that “Public policy on Indian education has been one of drift – a drift in response to the wind from whichever direction it might be blowing.”²³ The wind is still blowing from the powerful, but, one can see very well a counter-wind blowing from millions of parents eager to ensure education for their children as well as from a substantial

23 Sen A (1971), *The Crisis in Indian Education* (Lalbahadur Shastri Memorial Lecture, 1970); Hyderabad: Institute of Public Enterprise

section of dedicated teachers. The angry mother, with whom we began this report, is a perfect representative of those millions. Therefore, the larger society, especially teachers and education activists, have a dual role to play: delivering as much as possible and also make the government deliver. There is no contradiction between the two, rather they complement each other.



Appendix 1.

List of select primary schools with their adopted mode of teaching

Mode of teaching-learning	Name of the Schools	District
In-person interaction - individually by visiting the homes of the children, and in small groups in the localities; developing local resources in the form of local educated youths; and guiding the parents - and private tutors in cases - about the lessons to introduce to their wards	1. Krishnabati S.P.C.F.P School	Dakshin Dinajpur
	2. Poilana Mahagram F.P. School	Dakshin Dinajpur
	3. Abhaynagar Primary School	Nadia
	4. Sutighata Primary School	Murshidabad
	5. Salar Adarsha Primary School	Murshidabad
	6. Uttar Boiratiguri Kalibari S.P.Pry School	Jalpaiguri
	7. Railway Hindi S.P. Pry School	Alipurduar
	8. Vibekananda Jr. Basic School	North 24 Parganas
	9. Ghoshpur G.S.F.P. School	North 24 Parganas
	10. Raidighi Mahishgot F.P School	South 24 Parganas
	11. Tenya Bayenpara Pry School	Murshidabad
	12. Nayagram Primary School	Paschim Medinipur
	13. Rupnarayanpur Pry School	Paschim Medinipur
	14. Shishu Bharati Pry School	Murshidabad
	15. Amlat primary School	Purba Medinipur
	16. Basulia Dakshin Pali Pry School	Purba Medinipur
	17. Pana Board Primary School	Purba Medinipur
	18. Basudebpur Debendra Pry School	Purba Medinipur
	19. Durgachak R.C.New Pry School	Purba Medinipur
	20. Roypur F.P. School	Dakshin Dinajpur
	21. Tangramari Primary School	Murshidabad
	22. Shishu Shiksha Sadan Pry School	Kolkata
	23. Kamala Bidyamandir Pry School	Kolkata

Mode of teaching-learning	Name of the Schools	District
Teaching-learning from distance: Telephonic conversations and WhatsApp message and video meeting; developing and sharing with the children teaching materials, including texts, graphics, cartoons, videos, online teaching through local TV channels and You Tube.	24. Pareshnath Girls School	Kolkata
	25. Rajbhaban Jr. basic School	Kolkata
	26. Paikpara Raja Monindra Smriti Pry	Kolkata
	27. Bhabagachi Jr. Basic School	North 24 Parganas
	28. Sererati FP School	North 24 Parganas
	29. Ambari NO III S/C Primary School	Cooch Behar
	30. Cooch Behar Tea Estate Division 5th Plan Primary School	Cooch Behar
	31. Ichhaganj Govt. Primary School	Cooch Behar
	32. Railway Hindi S/P Primary School	Alipurduar
	33. Raidighi Mohishgot FP School	South 24 Parganas
	34. Palladaha FP School	North 24 Parganas
	1. Kishorepur Primary School	Nadia
	2. Sererati F.P. School	South 24 Parganas
	3. Nowpara Jr. Basic School	Dakshin Dinajpur
	4. Sharapul Hatkhola F.P. School	North 24 Parganas
	5. Banglani F.P. School	North 24 Parganas
	6. Rajanagar Primary School	Murshidabad
	7. Kalanchi Jr Basic School	North 24 Parganas
	8. Kuchlachati Pry School	Paschim Medinipur
	9. Milkipara tapshili Primary School	Murshidabad
	10. Vivekananda Primary School	Howrah
	11. Mahakali Pathshala Primary School	Murshidabad
	12. Naranda New Primary School	Purba Medinipur
	13. Bargharia 2 NO FP School	North 24 Parganas
	14. Purbachal Vidyapith GSFP School	Nadia

Mode of teaching-learning	Name of the Schools	District
	15. Chalitatali Prathamik Vidyalaya	Nadia
	16. Sharada Vidyapith (Primary Section)	Kolkata
	17. The Calcutta Orphanage Primary School	Kolkata
	18. Radhanagar Board Pry School	Bankura
	19. 46, Mandalpu Primary School	Murshidabad
	20. Sahid Nitya Dutta G.S.F.P. School	North 24 Parganas.

Appendix 2. Statistical Tables

Data collected during May-July 2021

**Table 2.1. Primary Students' Level of Learning in Select Areas of West Bengal
First Language**

District	Total students	Satisfactory	Average	Very poor	Total
Purulia	431	45.9	17.4	36.7	100
D.Dinajpur	579	52.5	28.5	19.0	100
Jhargram	1236	40.9	40.5	18.5	100
Howrah	365	49.1	28.6	22.3	100
Kolkata	639	53.2	27.3	19.5	100
Jalpaiguri	217	51.2	30.0	18.9	100
Purba Medinipur	389	54.9	25.7	19.4	100
Hoogli	300	38.3	38.7	23.0	100
Paschim Medinipur	287	39.7	27.2	33.1	100
Siliguri	150	46.7	28.7	24.7	100
Nadia	493	37.1	43.0	19.9	100
Murshidabad	724	45.2	30.2	24.6	100
North 24 Parganas	1394	42.0	32.7	25.3	100
Total & Average	7204	45.9	30.6	23.4	100

Table2.2. Primary Students' Level of Learning in Select Areas of West Bengal**Arithmetic**

District	Total students	Satisfactory	Average	Very poor	Total
Purulia	431	43.6	34.8	21.6	100
D.Dinajpur	579	47.5	30.7	21.8	100
Jhargram	1236	37.5	37.3	25.2	100
Howrah	365	49.1	29.6	21.3	100
Kolkata	639	49.7	26.8	23.5	100
Jalpaiguri	217	38.2	40.6	21.2	100
Purba Medinipur	389	53.4	25.9	20.7	100
Hoogli	300	35.0	40.0	25.0	100
Paschim Medinipur	287	34.5	27.5	38.0	100
Siliguri	150	46.7	28.7	24.7	100
Nadia	493	28.0	42.4	29.6	100
Murshidabad	724	43.6	30.5	25.8	100
North 24 Parganas	1394	35.9	36.9	27.2	100
Total & Average	7204	41.7	33.2	25.0	100

Table 2.3. Primary Students' Level of Learning in Select Areas of West Bengal
Second Language

District	Total students	Satisfactory	Average	Very poor	Total
Purulia	431	39.9	40.6	19.5	100
D.Dinajpur	579	48.2	30.9	20.9	100
Jhargram	1236	38.9	30.9	30.2	100
Howrah	365	49.1	27.3	23.6	100
Kolkata	639	48.2	29.0	22.8	100
Jalpaiguri	217	30.9	39.6	29.5	100
Purba Medinipur	389	49.4	28.7	21.9	100
Hoogli	300	40.3	36.3	23.3	100
Paschim Medinipur	287	32.4	24.0	43.6	100
Siliguri	150	46.7	28.7	24.7	100
Nadia	493	23.5	40.2	36.3	100
Murshidabad	724	46.3	30.0	23.8	100
North 24 Parganas	1394	33.4	36.1	30.5	100
Total & Average	7204	40.6	32.5	27.0	100

Table 2.4. Primary Students' Level of Learning in Select Areas of West Bengal**Environment studies**

District	Total students	Satisfactory	Average	Very poor	Total
Purulia	431	40.8	29.5	29.7	100
D.Dinaipur	579	56.0	26.6	17.4	100
Jhargram	1236	41.4	41.3	17.2	100
Howrah	365	49.7	25.4	24.9	100
Kolkata	639	52.3	26.4	21.3	100
Jalpaiguri	217	50.2	27.8	22.0	100
Purba Medinipur	389	54.8	27.5	17.7	100
Hoogli	300	53.3	36.7	10.0	100
Paschim Medinipur	287	44.6	27.9	27.5	100
Siliguri	150	46.7	28.7	24.7	100
Nadia	493	40.2	33.3	26.6	100
Murshidabad	724	50.8	28.7	20.4	100
North 24 Parganas	1394	40.8	31.7	27.5	100
Total & Average	7204	47.8	30.1	22.1	100

Table 2.5. Primary Students' Level of Learning in Select Areas of West Bengal**Average**

District	Total students	Satisfactory	Average	Very poor	Total
Purulia	431	42.6	30.6	26.9	100
D.Dinajpur	579	51.0	29.2	19.8	100
Jhargram	1236	39.7	37.5	22.8	100
Howrah	365	49.2	27.7	23.0	100
Kolkata	639	50.9	27.4	21.8	100
Jalpaiguri	217	42.6	34.5	22.9	100
Purba Medinipur	389	53.1	27.0	19.9	100
Hoogli	300	41.8	37.9	20.3	100
Paschim Medinipur	287	37.8	26.7	35.5	100
Siliguri	150	46.7	28.7	24.7	100
Nadia	493	32.2	39.7	28.1	100
Murshidabad	724	46.5	29.9	23.7	100
North 24 Parganas	1394	38.0	34.3	27.6	100
Total & Average	7204	44.0	31.6	24.4	100

Table 3.1. Changes in food consumption in select rural and urban households (N= 369)

(1) Food items	(2) Consumption before Covid19 (in KG)	(3) Consumption during Covid19(in KG)	Percent Change ((2-3)/2)*100
Cereals	16902	14566	13.8
Pulses	743	581	21.8
Fish	1141	766	32.9
Meat	635	358	43.6
Vegetables	9454	7172	24.1

Table 3.2. Changes in monthly income in select rural and urban households (N= 369)

Household Income (per month)	Number of Households			
	Before Covid19	Percent change	During Covid19	Percent change
0	0	0	3	0.81301
1.00 - 1000	24	6.5	29	7.85908
1001.00 - 5000	87	23.6	168	45.52846
5001.00 - 10000	154	41.7	126	34.14634
10001.00 - 20000	78	21.1	31	8.40108
Above 20000	26	7.0	12	3.25203
Number of HH	369	100	369	100

Table 3.3. Decline in number of earners and monthly income

	Before the Pandemic	During the pandemic	Decline	Percent change
Total earners	448	421	27	6.0
Total monthly income	3575000	2475200	1099800	30.8

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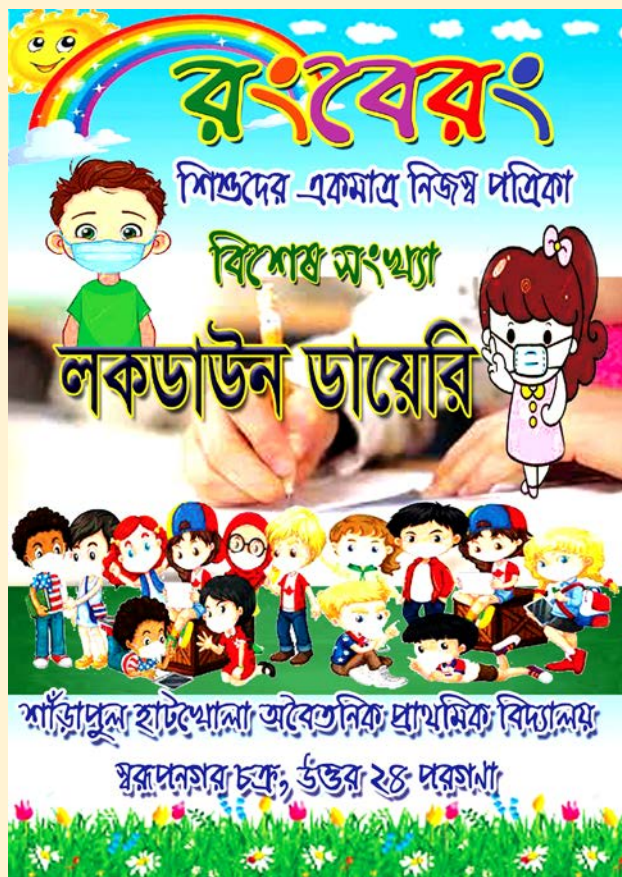
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Learning Together records the plight of primary education during the pandemic, and the human condition of the children shut out from school. It offers a set of concrete, practical steps to reach out to the children, not only pedagogically but to ensure their total well-being. These proposals, and the outlook they embody, can be the starting point of an agenda of educational consolidation beyond the special context of the pandemic, compelling though that is.

